Barrio Gonzales

Ahliyah Luna

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My home is forty-five kilometers from the city, though we call it a "city" only because of the two-story mall planted at its center. Nothing else about it feels like a city. Just the largest public building you can escape into during the summer heat, chilled by free air conditioning and bright fluorescent lights that buzz overhead like flies. Outside the mall, the streets thin out. The stores are sparse, tucked miles apart, each one a half-hour walk under the sun. Between them stretches long silence—just rice fields shimmering in the heat, their waterlogged paddies reflecting the sky like cracked mirrors.

Tricycles rattle through these empty stretches, piled with sacks of rice, hollow blocks, or schoolchildren clutching umbrellas against the glare. Even the roadside eateries feel temporary: a few plastic tables under a corrugated roof, their menus handwritten and fading. The gas station at the edge of the town has only two pumps, and when they both stall, everyone waits—jeepneys lined up, drivers smoking in the shade of a mango tree. Chickens wander freely; the streets go black after nine, save for the occasional karaoke bar lit in pink neon, where voices carry across the fields until frogs and crickets drown them out.

The drive home winds through three *barrios* where *sari-sari* stores lean against each other like tired relatives, three markets with tarpaulins sagging under monsoon stains, and finally, a red bridge stretched over a river that swallows the unlucky whole. Dozens have died there, I've heard. Motorcycles skidding on slick nights, buses with brakes that suddenly failed. One of them was my godfather. My mother grew up crossing that same bridge. Every time I pass, I keep my head low, afraid of the faces I might catch in the water's surface.

In town, it has become a fable: a woman in a white nightgown appearing at night, creeping closer as your headlights cut across the bridge—no different from the ghost stories about *Balete Drive*. Some say she steps into the road to drag you to her fate; others say she waits, perched on the railing, seducing you toward the afterlife. In one telling, she was eighteen when she leapt into the river after a broken engagement, and her body was never recovered. In another, she was a victim of a hit-and-run, left broken on the asphalt until she bled out alone. Whichever version you believe, the end is the same: her shadow slipping into your vehicle, her hand cold on your shoulder, her face the last thing you see before the river takes you too.

They fail to mention the simpler truth—that the motorcycles on that road are always driven by men too drunk to stay upright, or buses barreling down from the north at three in the morning, drivers heavy-eyed and speeding. But in stories, it's easier to blame the woman in white.

My home sits past the basketball court, the one ringed by rusting hoops and bottle shards pressed into the dirt for boundary lines. Ours is the house with the red gate too short for thieves to bother climbing, wires strung along the sides—-thicker than barbed wire, but just barely, and loose in places where rats have chewed through. The balcony roof is patched with *cogon* grass that leaks whenever the rain decides to be heavy. To the left: bamboo chairs, polished only by the sweat of those who sit too long. To the right: a *papag*, wooden slats nailed together, that promises rest but only leaves your back aching.

I spent a lot of time there, sitting barefoot, drinking cola from a plastic bag, sweat dripping down my shins, mud prints stamped across my soles, bruises blooming on my knees. The stray dogs sprawled nearby—bone-thin, ribs pressing through their fur—as other barefoot kids gathered at the court, our laughter sharp in the heat. We darted across the highway like it was a game we invented to cheat. None of our mothers screaming after us, none of our fathers yanking our wrists. We just knew how to dodge—the cars, the jeeps, the buses—like it was a skill we were born with.

Christmas time was the hit of the town, when the basketball court transformed into the center of everything. Recycled festival décor hung from wires—tinsel cuts from old chip wrappers, lanters made out of Coke bottles, the colors dulled but still catching the light. The speaker's borrowed from someone's uncle, hissed and popped with static before wheezing out old *Ilokano Baile*. The sound was distorted and faint, but loud enough to draw everyone in. The vendors stayed late, grilling skewers that smoked up the air, sweet and greasy. Dogs nosed through the scraps under the tables. Someone always set off a firecracker too close, sending us scattering before the laughter pulled us back together.

The music drew in single men in their twenties, shirts already damp, cigarette ash clinging to their legs. They circled us girls—pigtailed, with holes in our blouses—and when the rhythm hit, the men grabbed our arms, pulled us close onto the dusty floor. It was on those Christmas nights that I would be kissed, tongues clumsy, hands wandering over cotton hems, pressing where they shouldn't. It only happened in December, but grew hotter, rougher as the years go by—until by fifteen I stopped letting myself get dragged back into the circle. I stayed home instead.

Most of the kids I grew up with were pregnant or married by sixteen. My neighbor was fourteen. A girl, also fourteen, was gang-raped just a few meters from our house. Thirteen boys were involved—the youngest in seventh grade, the oldest in ninth. My cousin whispered that some of them had once been his classmates in elementary school. None of them were sent to

juvenile centers. They still played ball on the court, still bought soda from the store, still laughed as if nothing had happened.

The town talked, but not about them.

At the barber shop, under the humming dan and the smell of bay rum, the men said, "She was too fast for her age," while hair fell in soft rings on the tiled floor. The barber tapped his comb against the glass, cluck of tongue, shake of head. On the mirror, a calendar girl arched over January. "If my daughter did that," my father said, "I'd lock her inside." He glared at me with contempt, and laughter popped around the room like knuckles cracking in unison.

On the church steps after Mass, rosaries clicked against wrists, beads clattering like loose teeth. "Out that late?" the catechist asked no one in particular, eyes pinned to the ground. The priest didn't mention her name in the homily; instead, he spoke of temptation, of keeping watch, and of wolves among lambs. Mothers pressed their palms onto their daughter's shoulders as though they were pinning wings back down.

At the market, fish eyes stared from trays of melting ice. "Her parents should've trained her better," the *bangus* vendor said, scooping vinegar into plastic cups. Scales glittered across her forearms like sequins. "Kids today," the next vendor chimed in, weighing tomatoes with a rusted scale, "don't know how to say no." A man picking through chillies muttered, "She must have wanted it. No one lets thirteen boys in if they didn't want it."

"Why didn't she scream?" someone else asked, twisting a bundle of *kangkong* into twine.

The school made new rules after. At the gate, prefects crouched with rulers, measuring hems against knees. Girls tugged at fabric that had always been the same length, pulling it lower, folding it differently. The guidance counselor sat with her ledger, drawing red lines down names like tally marks. By midmorning, a few girls were already walking home, heads bent, blouses clinging transparent in the sun. Hair was trimmed at the shoulders, black strands falling in uneven clumps to the floor of the classroom. The smell of acetone lingered in the restroom after a bottle of nail polish was confiscated and emptied into the sink.

The boys arrived late anyway. They came in clusters, shirts half-buttressed, still chewing breakfast, high-fiving by the canteen where flies circled trays of caramelized bananas. Their voices filled the courtyard, louder than the bell, laughter that snapped all the way into the hallways. Teachers said *misunderstanding* was like a new subject, something to be conjugated until it lost its bite. In the faculty room, the walls are lined with curling posters of multiplication tables, someone whispered. *Sayang ang kinabukasan*. Chalk dust hovered like smoke.

"Was it good?" I head someone ask the boys at lunch.

At the barangay hall, the captain leaned on the desk, ceiling fan rattling overhead. Soft drinks were poured into paper cups, bubbles hissing loud enough to cover the silence. "Let's not make trouble," he said, as if trouble were a stain that could spread if named. Envelopes appeared,

folded and plain, tucked under clipboards already stained with carbon ink. By afternoon, the paper trail was buried under newer stacks: noise complaints, barangay IDs, permits.

The death of the three women, exactly three houses apart from each other, stole the show. For weeks, it was all the town spoke of—three wakes burning along the same road, each house spilling with borrowed monobloc chairs, coffee ladled into chipped cups, men shuffling decks of cards until dawn. At night, the street throbbed with the electric hum of generators and the sweetness of sampaguita garlands wilting in the heat.

I went to all of them, mostly for the fish crackers and the overnight gambling—I must have lost three hundred person, one hundred for each house. The first was for my aunt's cousin, who wasted away from cancer, her body thin as the bamboo poles holding up the tarp above her coffin. Three houses, an old woman my father had known as a child, remembered mostly for her guava tree and the way she used to chase children with a broom, her curses sharp enough to stick. Three houses farther, another woman I never really knew, though her yard always smelled of boiled peanuts. She lived only four houses away from us, and I felt bad for our neighbor who lived one house closer to her.

The first funeral I ever attended was long before those—my great-grandfather's. He had taught me to eat rice dusted with powdered milk and sugar, sweet enough to trick an empty stomach. He died of diabetes. His funeral taught me how to play card games, the clack of coins and the shuffle of worn decks carrying me through the night while his coffin lay open under strings of Christmas lights.

In his last months, nearly blind, they taped his eyelids open so he would not forget daylight. When I was small, he put me to sleep with stories of the Japanese occupation—how his wife smeared chicken blood onto her underwear so the soldiers would leave her alone. He told it with pride, as though survival was wit. And then in the same voice, he told the story of how he courted her: waiting under her window at night, lingering at her doorstep, reaching for her in the dark until she relented. How he grabbed her wrist, caressed her arm, refused to let go until she agreed to marry him.

Their love story was a tale people liked to tell: his pursuit, his insistence, his endless circling until she gave in. At family gatherings, it was repeated like a lesson—how he never stopped chasing, how she finally surrendered. Devotion, they called it. Determination. Proof of love. And so the story held: he got the girl, and they stayed together until the very end.

AHUMAFILIPINA

What I remember the most were my grandmother's tears. It was the first time I saw her heartbroken, but the last time I saw her cry.

There was the time she chased my grandfather down the street, hurling his shirts and trousers after him, her hair loose, her voice cracking in front of neighbors, because he had impregnated her fifteen-year-old niece. The men laughed from their porches, saying he still had the fire in him; the women looked away, muttering that she was bringing shame to herself by making it public. She didn't stop until the last shirt fell into the gutter.

There was the time I caught her at the sink, sleeves rolled up, wrists bent under the water, scrubbing suds over dark bruises until her skin turned raw. She looked at me and smiled to quickly. Another time, she stayed in bed for days, curtains drawn, the whole house dim. No one asked why. The neighbors said she was lazy, her daughters whispered that she was ill, but I saw the stillness on her face, an absence no one wanted to give words to.

She also wept when my mother had left my father one morning, a suitcase packed before dawn. To her, it was betrayal. Her son didn't deserve it, she said, though I had seen my shoulder flinch from his hand. My grandmother wept again when my aunt stumbled home barefoot, cheeks swollen, saying her husband had locked her out in the rain. She pressed her daughter close, kissing all her bruises.

My mother came back to take me away one night. She appeared by my school gate that afternoon, her voice softer than I remembered, talking to me about Manila. She said that the city never slept, that the streets glowed with lights brighter than day. She said malls stacked on top of each other, then floors high, cold with air conditioning, where you could eat ice cream in December without ever sweating. She told me about sidewalks lined with vendors—fried quail eggs on sticks, roasted corn brushed with margarine, smoke rising from charcoal. She said movie theaters played all night, and bars never closed.

I waited until every light in the house had gone out, until the dogs quieted, until only the sound of my bare feet against the floorboards broke the silence. I remember my grandmother's eye framed in the jalousie, the slats tilted just enough to catch me as I left. Her gaze held everything at once—resignation, blessing. She raised her hand and waved me off with a smile that was both bitter and sweet, letting me go and holding me forever in the same breath.

I hadn't seen her before she died. I heard she was sick, that she was bedridden, that her body had sunk into the mattress until it left a hollow.

I avoided her letters for weeks, then months. Each time I picked up a pen, the words blurred into tears, and the tears soured into embarrassment, then embarrassment into shame. I

told myself I would try again the next day. Instead, I called and told her to wait. I promised I would be home soon.

But I didn't come home until a decade later. In those ten years, I had finished school. I had worked as a secretary at a law firm. At twenty-one, I had my first marriage; at twenty-five, I had run away, just as predicted by my lineage of women who fled, who endured, who were punished.

And then I was back, standing on dirt, staring down at a slab of stone. Her epitaph was short: *Always Remembered*.

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